



Clare's Sustainable Destination Certification: Recognising Your Contribution

Tourism Department, Clare County Council,

Visit Clare

11.11.25



Agenda

- 1. Welcome and Context (5 mins)**
- 2. Clare's Sustainable Destination Certification (10 mins)**
- 3. Recognised Contributor Badges: Purpose and Criteria (15 mins)**
- 4. Visual Identity and Use Guidelines of Recognised Contributor Badge (15 mins)**
- 5. Feedback and Discussion (10 mins)**
- 6. Next Steps and Closing (5 mins)**

1. Welcome and Context

- **Opening remarks – Deirdre O’Shea, Senior Executive Officer Tourism, Festivals and Events, Clare County Council**
- **Brief introduction to Clare’s Sustainable Destination journey** (Carol Gleeson, Manager of the Burren & Cliffs of Moher UNESCO Geopark).
- **The Badge initiative** Fiona McKenna, Sustainable Destination Development Officer
- **International Perspective.** Dr. James Hanrahan, Tourism Lecturer, The Atlantic Technological University

County Clare's Tourism Strategy 2030



Guiding our Journey to a Vibrant **New Future** in Tourism

County Clare Tourism Strategy 2030



THE STRATEGY OVERVIEW

Our 2030 Vision: CLARE is a globally renowned sustainable and vibrant destination, recognised for its compelling array of adventure activities and its remarkable experiences portraying our rich culture-scape of age-old spirituality, power and influence; our contemporary vitality arising from our deep-rooted traditions in music, sport and innovation; our dynamic rural towns and villages where our hospitality excels – all set within our stunning backdrop of unique and varied living landscapes.

Our goals:

To work collaboratively:

1. To deliver compelling quality experiences that reflect and leverage our unique identity.
2. To be globally recognised as a sustainable destination.
3. To create a smart destination that reflects our strong commitment to sustainability, connectivity, innovation and new approaches to doing business.
4. To be regarded as 'the gateway to the west'.
5. To spread the benefits of tourism across the county and throughout the seasons in a way that enriches our communities while maintaining our distinctive identity and the integrity of our landscapes.



2. UNESCO Global Geopark & the Geopark Code of Practice

- **UNESCO Global Geoparks** are internationally recognised places with unique geology, landscapes, history and culture.
- Geoparks are managed with a focus on education, conservation, sustainable tourism and community engagement (Designation is revalidated against set criteria every 4 years).
- The **Burren Ecotourism Network** established 2008 and the Code of Practice established 2016
- Businesses a vital part of sustainable destinations, contributing to communities & conservation, economic well being.
- Producing environmental, economic, social and cultural data informing Environmental Action Plans
- **Online system, Externally validated, Audit every 2 years**



CLARE COUNTY COUNCIL
CLARE COUNTY COUNCIL

BURREN AND CLIFFS OF MOHER UNESCO Global Geopark

Logged in as Fiona McKenna Logout

Input Waste, Water & Energy Consumption Data

Step 1: Input Waste, Water & Energy Consumption Data

• Only those Burren operators who have a premises or provide transport are required to provide consumption data.
• Operators who have measured and recorded data for previous years as part of a Code of Practice submission have the option to input it here. This will allow tracking over time.
• The data is not reported to the public information for a resource user who do not use in your business.
• Download the Guide to Completing the Consumption Data Tables here.

	2024	2023
Landfill By Weight	Kg/per	0.62304
Recycling By Weight	Kg/per	0.52540
Food Waste By Weight	Kg/per	0.26361
Water	m ³ /per	0.56204
Oil	Ltr/per	0.18990
Gas / LPG	Ltr/kwh/per	0.18990



By adopting the Geopark Code of Practice for Sustainable Tourism,
we commit to a process of continuous improvement in sustainable tourism practice.

The Code observes the following principles:

WORKING TOGETHER

We collaborate with all stakeholders to collectively develop the Geopark as a sustainable tourism destination.

A CARED-FOR LANDSCAPE

We actively participate in conserving our natural and cultural heritage.

A WELL-UNDERSTOOD HERITAGE

We offer quality information and interpretation to communicate our stories and the unique character of our place to guests.

VIBRANT COMMUNITIES

We work to ensure that tourism makes a positive social contribution so that it benefits our community as well as our guests. We aim to make our services available to the widest possible audience.

STRENGTHENED LIVELIHOODS

We contribute to the local economy by maintaining and supporting local employment, by sourcing services and produce locally wherever possible, and by engaging with other businesses in promoting our region as a sustainable tourism destination.

SUSTAINABLE ENVIRONMENTAL MANAGEMENT

We work to an Environmental Action Plan, which includes targets for improvement that are reviewed annually. We have effective systems for monitoring and adequately managing our waste, water, wastewater and energy

2. Clare's Sustainable Destination Certification process



2. Clare's Sustainable Destination Certification

On the **9th of April 2025**, Clare County Council was awarded **EarthCheck Silver Certified achievement** for 2024 for County Clare as a destination.



COMHAIRLE CONTAE AN CHLÁIR
CLARE COUNTY COUNCIL

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Clare becomes First Countywide Certified Sustainable Tourism Destination in Ireland

14 April 2025

County Clare has been successful in its bid to become the first countywide certified sustainable tourism destination in Ireland.



The Banner County has been awarded Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC) Destination Certification, recognised as a global leader in managing standards for sustainable travel and tourism, following a visit to Clare last month by certifying body EarthCheck.

2025

THIS IS TO CERTIFY THAT

CLARE COUNTY COUNCIL

HAS BEEN ASSESSED AS MEETING SILVER CERTIFICATION
(1 YEAR) REQUIREMENTS OF THE EARTHCHECK
DESTINATION STANDARD V3.0

DESTINATION

CERTIFICATION INCLUDES THE FOLLOWING ELEMENTS:
COUNTY CLARE IS LOCATED ON THE WESTERN SEABOARD OF THE ISLAND OF THE REPUBLIC OF IRELAND AND COVERS AN AREA OF 3,450 KM². COUNTY COUNCILS PROVIDE HUNDREDS OF SERVICES RANGING FROM ROADS; PLANNING; HOUSING; ECONOMIC AND COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT; ENVIRONMENT, HERITAGE, RECREATION, AND AMENITY SERVICES.

Stewart Moore, CEO
EarthCheck
5/189 Grey Street
South Brisbane
Queensland, 4101
Australia



EARTHCHECK
SILVER CERTIFIED

A-DEST-8254-0109

Certification Date: 9/04/2025
Expiry Date: 9/04/2026

Clare County Council
New Road
Ennis V95 DXP2
County Clare
Ireland

Clare joins other global leading destinations in achieving the ambitious certification :

- Zurich
- Copenhagen
- Maderia
- The Azores

We Care,
Zürich, Switzerland.

AI Guide Search Menu

EarthCheck certified

Zurich is the first Swiss city to achieve the prestigious EarthCheck certification

The destination of Zurich was recognised as a sustainable destination in 2024 by [EarthCheck](#), the globally recognised certification body for sustainable tourism. This certification, initiated by Zürich Tourism, is proof of Zürich's high quality standards and its commitment to environmental and social responsibility. The award is the result of intensive cooperation between the city and the tourism organisation.

[Press Release](#)

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Convention Bureau » Copenhagen achieves EarthCheck Sustainable Destination Certification

copenhagen
convention bureau



Copenhagen achieves EarthCheck Sustainable Destination Certification

25.4.2025

Photo: Daniel Rasmussen

Copenhagen's green efforts have yielded further results, as the Danish capital has received a sustainability certification that only very few destinations have achieved so far; the EarthCheck Sustainable Destination Certification.

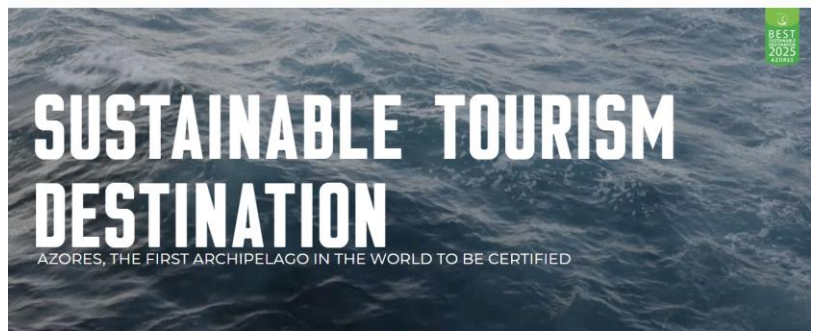
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AZORES
NATURE DESTINATION

Explore

English



The Azores are a destination for nature and experiences, focused on the preservation of resources and the preservation of the archipelago's natural legacy.



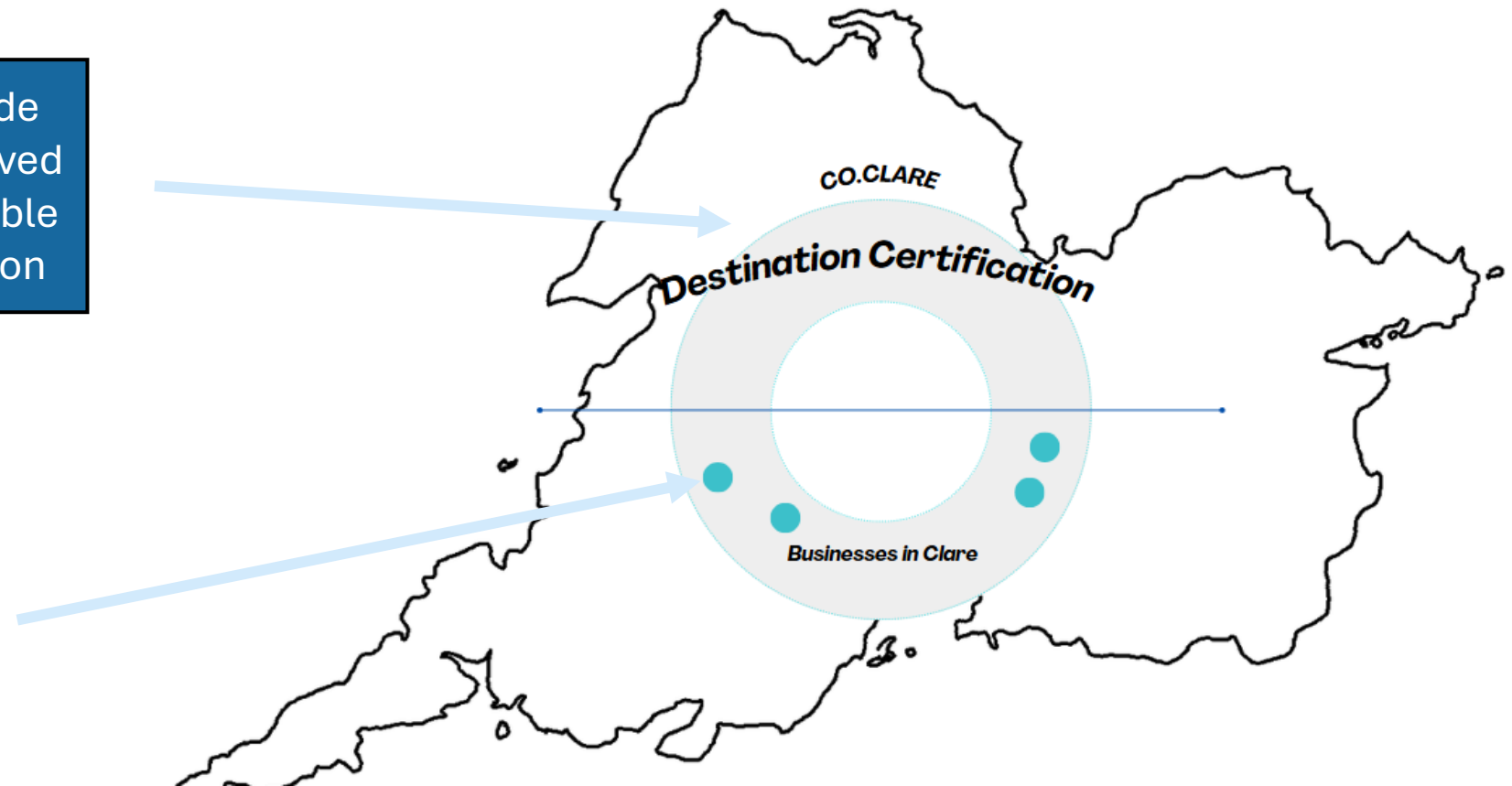
What does this mean?

- Clare has become the **first certified Sustainable destination** in Ireland and the British Isles.
- It does not mean Clare is 100% sustainable (impossible to achieve for any destination), but it means that Clare is committed to **process of improvement**.
- Clare now has a **framework** to operate within to build a more sustainable and resilient destination
- Clare is now able to **discuss and market the destination** as a sustainable destination, in a verified manner.

What part of businesses play in Co. Clare's Sustainable Destination Certification

Clare, as a county wide destination, has achieved Ireland's first sustainable destination certification

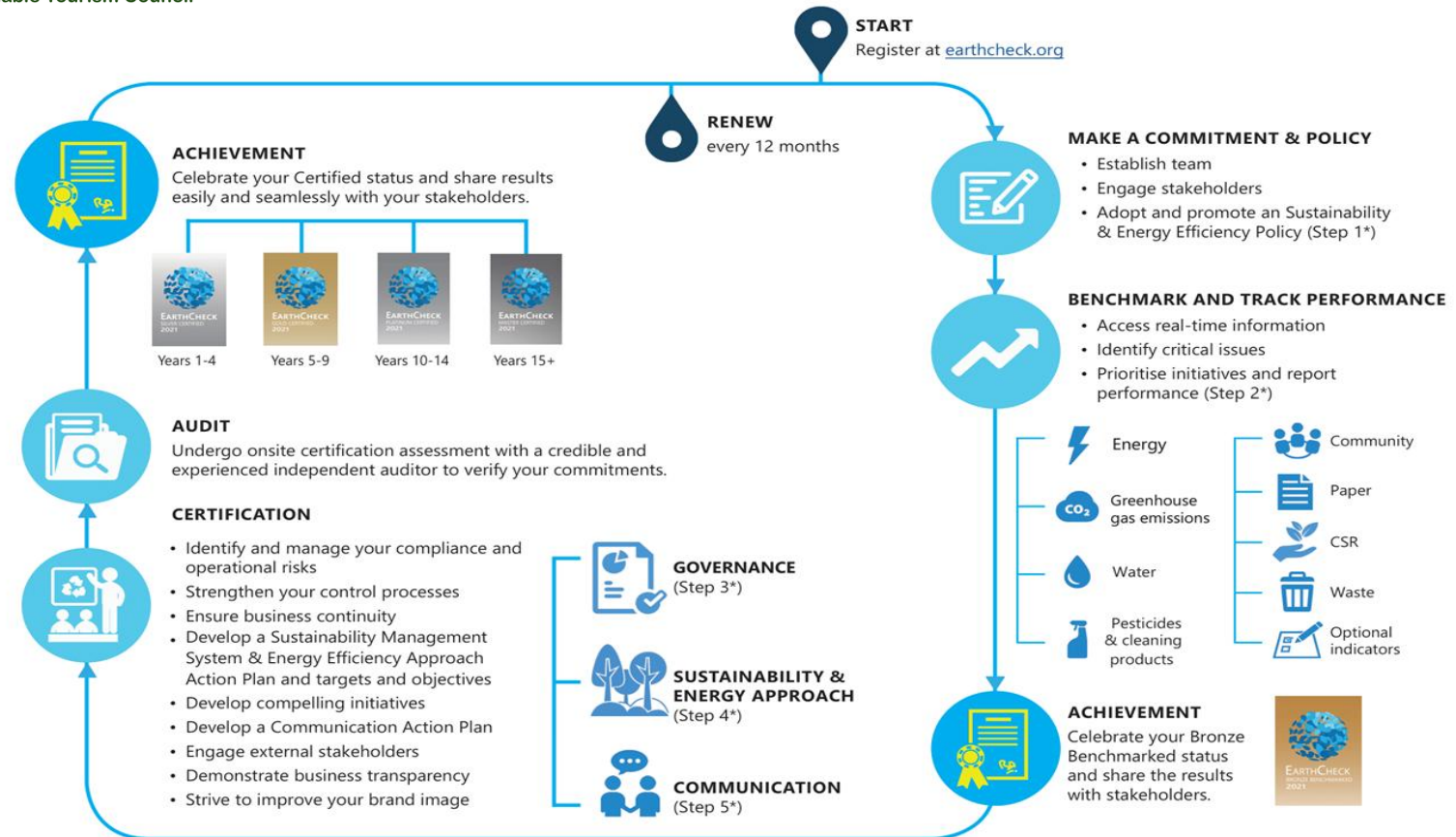
Clare's enterprises are a **key** part of our destination.
(Not the only part of our destination certification, which also includes transport, infrastructure, community engagement etc).



Approach to take a county wide approach to sustainability: *Sustainable Destination Certification*



- Third party verified
- Based on global standard: Global Sustainable Tourism Council



*Refer to EarthCheck Company Standard

Intensive on-site audit



COMHAIRLE | CLARE
CONTAE AN CHLÁIR | COUNTY COUNCIL



First audit based on infrastructure in Clare – next year, a focus on local businesses

Co. Clare's Destination Green Team members



- Tourism Department, Clare County Council
- Environment and Climate Action Department, Clare County Council
- Municipal Districts, Clare County Council
- Rural and Community Development Department, Clare County Council
- Heritage, Biodiversity and Planning Department, Clare County Council
- Burren & Cliffs of Moher UNESCO Global Geopark, Clare County Council
- Clare Collections, Clare Tourism Development DAC
- Irish Farmers Association
- North Clare Community Group
- Burren Ecotourism Network
- East Clare Tourism Network
- Loop Head Tourism Network
- Private tourism businesses
- Fáilte Ireland
- National Parks and Wildlife
- Office of Public Works
- Geological Survey of Ireland
- National Monuments Service
- Limerick Clare Conference and Sports Bureau
- Shannon Airport
- Atlantic Sustainable Tourism Observatory, Atlantic Technology University, Sligo, Ireland



What part of businesses play in Co. Clare's Sustainable Destination Certification

A key metric within the destination certification is to measure the individual businesses that are operating within the destination on a sustainability framework themselves.

- **Indicator:** *What percentage (%) of travel and tourism operators in the community have environmental accreditation:*

Our score in Clare: **17%** (10% better than Earth Check's Best Practice Level)

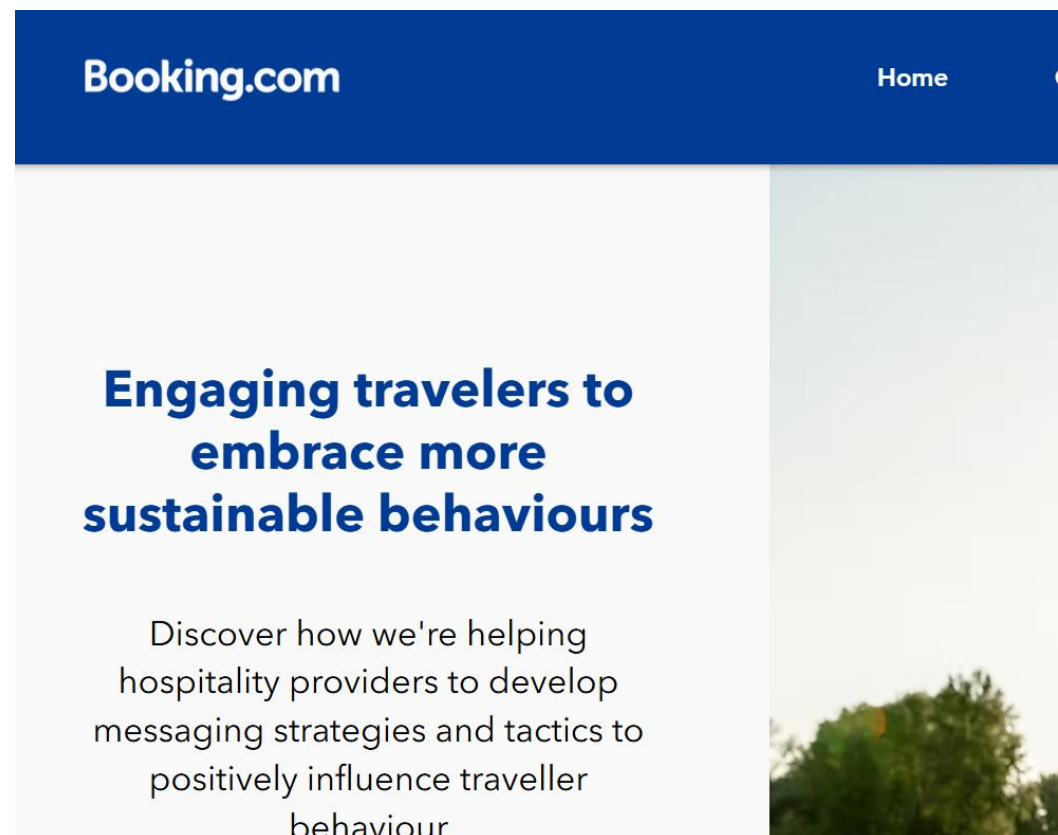
A lot of these are made up of the **Burren Ecotourism Network**, who complete the Code of Practice for sustainable tourism, and so will be given this badge to recognise their commitment. Third party certifications will also be included.



Responding to the Market

- **75-80 %** of travellers say sustainability matters in their travel choices*
- **59% of global travellers want to filter their stay** options for those with a sustainability certification next time they book.
- **65% of travellers** surveyed by Booking.com would feel better about staying in a particular accommodation if they knew it had a **sustainability certification**.
- **AI** travel itineraries – will identify and highlight **verified** sustainability enterprises (first), especially when published by established tourism webpages such as Visit Clare.

**UN Tourism (2024 Barometer) and Booking.com's 2024 Sustainable Travel Report*





3. Recognised Contributor Badges: Purpose and Criteria

Why the recognised contributor badge system was developed

- The Recognised Contributor badge was created to **acknowledge** and **celebrate tourism businesses that actively contribute to Clare's collective sustainability journey.**
- While not a certification in itself, it provides visible recognition for those already engaged in **recognised, measurable sustainable practice.**



3. Recognised Contributor Badges: Purpose and Criteria

Why the recognised contributor badge system was developed

- In Clare, we are **uniquely positioned** to take advantage of our sustainability credentials.
- Committed to a **just transition** to bring small **SME's** with us on the journey through funding from the Tourism Department, Clare Council.
- On top of being the first destination in Ireland to achieve GSTC recognised sustainable destination certification, we have approx. **70 third party evaluated businesses** (and growing).
- Most counties in Ireland may only have 3-5 (this is mostly due to the Geopark Code of Practice).

3. Recognised Contributor Badges: Purpose and Criteria

Inclusion criteria

To be listed as a Recognised Contributor, a business must demonstrate the following:

Verified participation in a **recognised sustainability framework**, such as :

- the Burren & Cliffs of Moher UNESCO Global Geopark Code of Practice for Sustainable Tourism, or a
- recognised third-party certifications (e.g. Green Hospitality, Origin Green etc.).



* representative examples

3. Recognised Contributor Badges: Purpose and Criteria

Recognition that aligns with relevant Irish and EU regulatory frameworks (ensuring credibility and transparency in sustainability communications)

- The recognition process aligns with current and emerging Irish and EU regulatory frameworks that aim to ensure sustainability communications are **credible, verifiable and transparent**.
- From Sep 2026, new EU Consumer and Unfair Commercial Practices Regulations will come into force, requiring all environmental and sustainability-related claims to be based on **evidence, independently verified** and **clearly communicated to consumers**.



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Unfair commercial practices directive

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Objective of the

Objective of the directive

3. Recognised Contributor Badges: Purpose and Criteria

- The Recognised Contributor system is designed to **evolve** and **adapt** in line with future EU and national regulations.
- Clare County Council and the Destination Green Team will **review, adapt and update** the recognition system to ensure continued **compliance, accuracy and integrity in all public communications**.



4. Visual Identity and Use Guidelines of Recognised Contributor Badge

Badge design (Digital & Decal format)

- Digital badge
- Decal format (will be delivered in the post).



4. Visual Identity and Use Guidelines of Recognised Contributor Badge

Badge design (Digital & Decal format)

- Approved use:

Websites, social media, premises and communications



4. Visual Identity and Use Guidelines of Recognised Contributor Badge



Clarification of disclaimers (non-certification; sustainability claims)

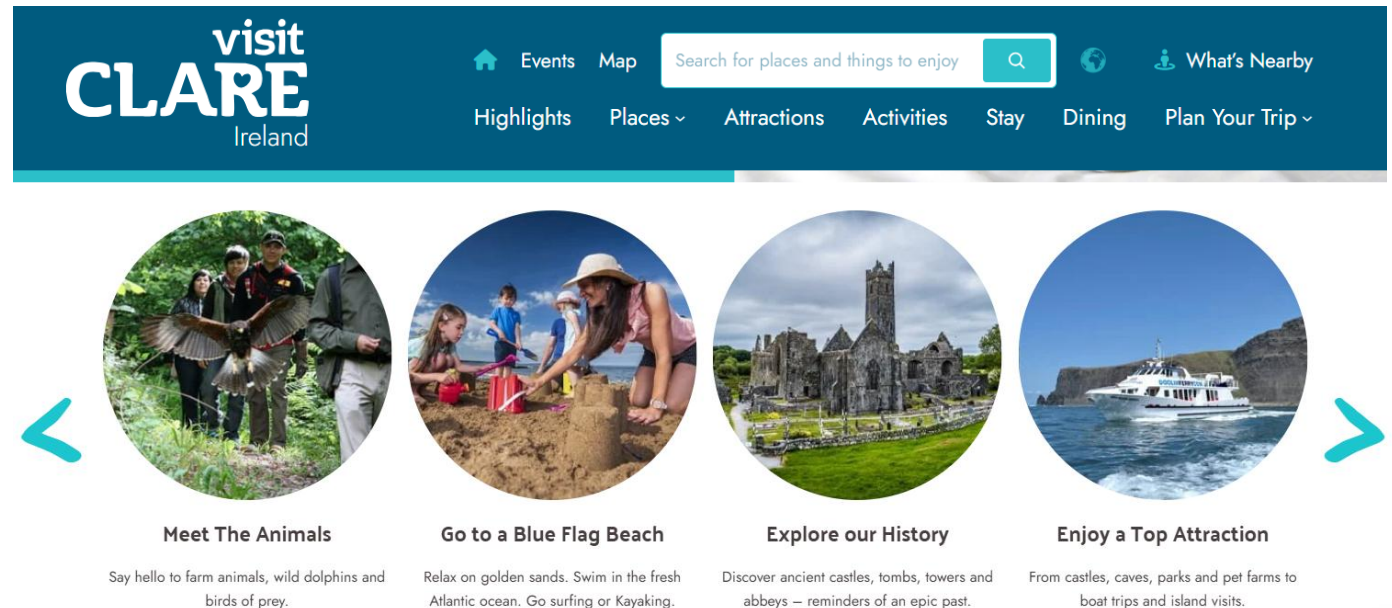
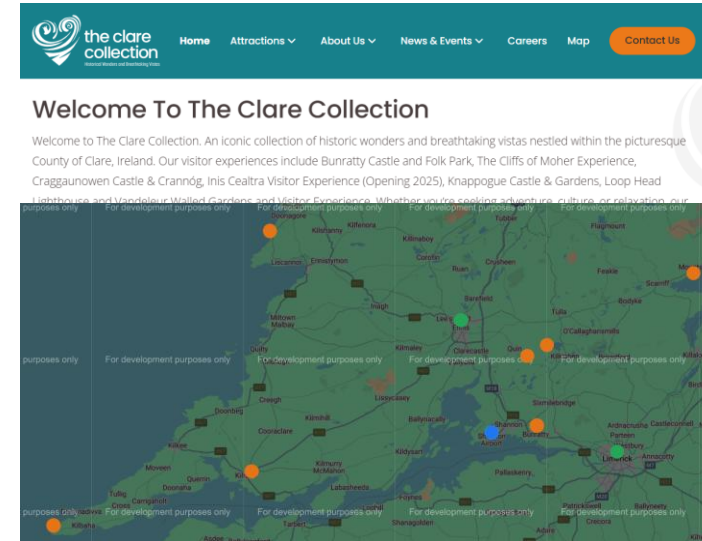
- Recognised Contributor badge represents inclusion in a verified destination-level sustainability framework, **not** individual certification.
- Businesses **must ensure** that any related claims or marketing materials remain accurate (up to date certifications) and transparent.
- **An easy to access, A4 page of terms of reference will also be sent to members.**



4. Visual Identity and Use Guidelines of Recognised Contributor Badge

Link with Clare's wider destination branding, marketing campaigns and National Tourism Ireland marketing campaigns

- Supports Clare's wider destination branding and marketing activities by reinforcing the county's reputation as an **authentic sustainable destination**.
- It aligns with **Visit Clare's** brand values - *Naturally Vibrant, Sustainably Yours* - and strengthens storytelling and product offerings.
- Build within **our strong tourism networks** and **the Clare Collections**.



4. Visual Identity and Use Guidelines of Recognised Contributor Badge

Opportunities

- Submission into successful National and International campaigns such as Tourism Ireland's ***"Ireland Unrushed"*** - ***Slow Tourism Campaign*** which celebrates slower, more meaningful travel experiences rooted in local culture and nature.
- Collaboration with **Failte Ireland** in their **sustainability approaches**
- Tourism Ireland, market targeted campaigns
- Creation of **sustainability-focused itineraries** within Visit-Clare



Ireland Unrushed campaign

Tourism Ireland's new global campaign – 'Ireland Unrushed' – was live across 13+ markets for the month of June 2025, showcasing new ways for overseas holidaymakers to explore the island and take time to enjoy our scenery, culture and heritage more deeply. Based on the insight that 80% of overseas visitors who choose our sun holidays are seeking a sense of

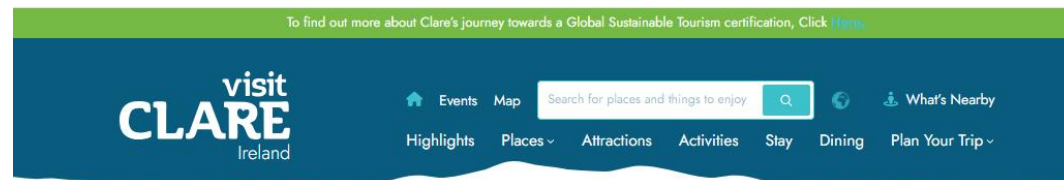
4. Feedback and Discussions

- Open floor for comments or questions
- Discussion on future opportunities for collaboration and storytelling



For more information

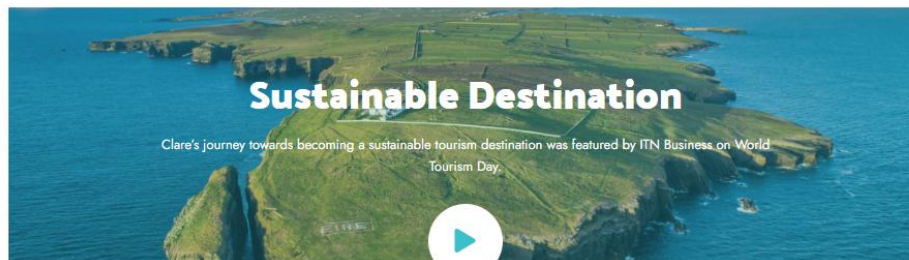
<https://visitclare.ie/sustainable/>



County Clare's Sustainable Journey



County Clare was announced as Ireland's first county-wide certified sustainable tourism destination in April 2025. By achieving Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC) certification, we are committed to continuing to develop our county as a destination that supports local communities and businesses, gives visitors great experiences, and manages our social, cultural, economic, and environmental future.



County Clare's Sustainable Tourism Journey



Tourism and community leaders have come together to successfully establish County Clare as the [first county-wide certified sustainable tourism destination](#) in Ireland. Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC) certification is helping us to continue to develop Clare as a destination that supports local communities and businesses, gives visitors great experiences and manages our social, cultural, economic, and environmental future.

[View More](#)

County Clare's Sustainable Tourism Policy



Embracing the region's rich heritage and stunning natural beauty, County Clare is deeply committed to leading the advancement towards a sustainable tourism future. Our Sustainable Tourism Policy underscores Clare County Council's firm commitment to evolving into a globally recognised destination dedicated to sustainability for the betterment of all.

[View Clare's Sustainable Tourism Policy](#)



Thank you

Fiona McKenna

Clare's Sustainable Destination Development Officer

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